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Scott O'Dell



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Dr. Seuss



Roald Dahl



Alan Garner



Charlotte Zolotow

Pied Pipers

Interviews with the influential
creators of children's literature

by Justin Wintle and Emma Fisher

**PADDINGTON
PRESS LTD**

**THE TWO CONTINENTS
PUBLISHING GROUP**

Library of Congress Cataloging in Publication Data

Wintle, Justin.
The Pied Pipers.

1. Authors, English—20th century-- Interviews.
 2. Authors, American--20th century Interviews.
 3. Illustrators Great Britain--Interviews.
 4. Illustrators--United States--Interviews.
 5. Children's literature--History and criticism.
- I. Fisher, Emma, 1949 joint author. II. Title.
PR106.W55 820'.9'9282 [B] 74-15918
ISBN 0-8467-0038-7

Library of Congress Catalog Card No. 74 15918

PHOTO CREDITS: *Maurice Sendak* by Nancy Crampton; *Edward Ardizzone* by John Hodder; *Laurent de Brunhoff* by Anne de Brunhoff; *Charlotte Zolotow* by Sidney Fields; *Richard Adams* by Peter Hirst-Smith; *Nicholas Stuart Gray* by Prue Grice; *Joan Aiken* by Rod Delroy; *Scott O'Dell* by Rudi Rath; *Madeleine L'Engle* by Bradford Bachrach; *Rumer Godden* by Crispian Woodgate; *Judy Blume* by John Blume.

Introduction and Interviews with *Maurice Sendak*, *Charles Keeping*, *Richard Scarry*, *Charlotte Zolotow*, *Roald Dahl*, *Richard Adams*, *Nicholas Stuart Gray*, *Scott O'Dell*, *Leon Garfield*, *Lloyd Alexander*, *Alan Garner*, *John Rowe Townsend*, *Madeleine L'Engle*, *Maia Wojciechowska* and *Judy Blume* all © Justin Wintle 1973 and 1974.

Interviews with *Edward Ardizzone*, *Laurent de Brunhoff*, *Joan Aiken*, *Rosemary Sutcliff*, *K. M. Peyton*, *Lucy Boston* and *Rumer Godden* all © Emma Fisher 1973 and 1974.

Letter from *Dr. Seuss* © Theodor S. Geisel 1974.

Letter from *E. B. White* © E. B. White 1974.

Printed in the U.S.A.

Designed by Richard Browner

IN THE U.S.A.

PADDINGTON PRESS LTD

TWO CONTINENTS

PUBLISHING GROUP

30 East 42nd Street

New York City, New York 10017

IN THE UNITED KINGDOM

PADDINGTON PRESS LTD

1 Wardour Street

London W1

IN CANADA

PADDINGTON PRESS LTD

distributed by

RANDOM HOUSE OF CANADA

370 Alliance Avenue

Toronto, Ontario

McKISSICK MEMORIAL LIBRARY
UNIVERSITY OF SOUTH CAROLINA
COLUMBIA, S. C. 29208

12 Scott O'Dell

Interviewed by Justin Wintle

Another author who turns to the past for subjects is Scott O'Dell; but unlike Joan Aiken he deals in history realistically, as a way of exploring social equations that are still present in his own society on the West Coast of the United States. Many of his themes are well established in the annals of American literature. *The King's Fifth* is a full-blooded tale about a corrupting and divisive lust for gold among a band of early Spanish settlers. *Sing Down The Moon* tells of the suffering of an Indian tribe pushed forever westward by the European conquest. *Island Of The Blue Dolphins*, winner of the 1961 Newberry Award and later made into a film of the same title, is about an Indian girl left alone on an island off the coast of California, an American equivalent of *Robinson Crusoe*.

O'Dell's preoccupations are probably best explained by his long and eventful life. Officially, he was born in Los Angeles just after the turn of the century; unofficially in 1899. His father was a railroad man, and the family moved around what was then the frontier land of Southern California. After leaving high school O'Dell attended the University of Wisconsin, where, already determined to become a writer, he quickly became disillusioned with his academic courses. He abandoned the idea of graduation and concentrated simply on those subjects that appealed to him—psychology, philosophy, English and history. This, he claims, has given him "a sense of comradeship with the students of today."

Having left Wisconsin, Scott O'Dell went into films, and, among other productions, worked as a second cameraman on the original version of *Ben Hur*. He spent a year with the Air Force in Texas during World War Two, and subsequently became the book editor of a Los Angeles newspaper. He wrote a number of books for adults during the fifties, and in the sixties his books for children. In 1972 he was awarded the Hans Christian Andersen Author's Medal.

Scott O'Dell lives near San Diego, within striking distance of the Mexican border, with his second wife, who edits the popular journal *Psychology Today*.

Q *Your recent children's books have been written for what is referred to as the Young Adult market. Why is that?*

A For one thing, we've found that here in the States children read more advanced books than parents and educators thought they could or would. Furthermore, there's a dearth of books for young adults, because they're not nearly as profitable for publisher or author. But there's an important need, so the last two books I've done have been in this field. One has just come out, called *Child of Fire*. The background is the Mexican border, just south of here. The story concerns five Chicano gangs and presents a problem that the ancestors of these boys met 400 years ago. Young Spaniards of the sixteenth-century, yearning for adventure, came to the Americas in search of gold. Their descendants, living in modern America, have the same desire for adventure, but no place to find it except in the world of drugs and pointless warfare. The Chicano, for all his proud heritage, is a prisoner of the *barrio*, a second-class citizen. *Child of Fire* deals with his problem, both realistically and symbolically and, I hope, with some understanding.

Q *Many of your books (one is tempted to say all your books) are concerned with traditional American themes, particularly themes of the frontier—conquest of new lands, what it's like to be midway between having laws made for you and making them for yourself, the conflict of interests between the old tribes and the new settlers, and the sense of opportunity given to youth. Is this because of the life you've led?*

A I've been asked that question before, and I've never given what I thought was an adequate answer. I've led a very full life, gone to many schools, done a lot of things, lived abroad extensively, been in a couple of wars. A mixed up sort of life, perhaps. I think the fact that I've written about the past has to do with this. It's not necessarily an escape (though I think there's part of that in it), or an attempt to look back at calmer times; rather I have the feeling that the present is the past and the past is the present. The fundamental human is about the same as he was a couple of thousand years ago. The basic changes have not been vast. Human needs for love, affection, understanding, a chance to succeed at something, are about the same. Although I may write about a Navajo girl (*Sing Down The Moon*), I feel that she is a contemporary. I just wanted to pay a tribute to the human spirit, and the fact that this spirit happened to be in an Indian girl is really incidental. I'm not interested in the Navajos particularly—they're not my favorite tribe even. They were marauders—they rode in and took the crops of other

Indians, after the harvest sometimes. But there was this thing that happened at the Canyon de Chelly. Carson and the government rounded up the Indians and drove them to Fort Sumner. The important thing was the story. If the story is a good story children will read it for the suspense, and you can use suspense to do things. In *Sing Down The Moon* I wanted to call children's attention to the fact that there are such things as endurance, as loyalty to your family, loyalty to the place where you live. Nowadays people are dispersed, can live anywhere they want to. That's the trouble here in California—we're just a bunch of uprooted people. You don't know your neighbor and he never speaks to you. But this Navajo girl—she did want to go back to where her family had lived and have a child and live in a cave on the side of the Canyon. Even though she knows her people were driven out, she still goes back and starts over again. I hope there's a lesson in this, an inspiration for children. It's very strong in me, this didactic, inspirational thing. I had a lot of circuit writers and educators in my family, going back for 150, 200 years. While I'm not formally religious, I think this messianic thing has rubbed off on me. I want to teach and say something to people. Adults have pretty well established their lives, but you can say something to children. If you can get their attention and their affection, then there is something that can really be done with children. You can tell a story and add something that might be of interest and importance in their lives. It is messianic. As I said I've had a particularly full life, which I've lived and don't want to talk about; and for the most part, with the possible exception of *The Child Of Fire* (which has some of my life in it) I have written about times before I was born. Perhaps leaving the present and going back furnishes sustenance of an emotional kind. But things haven't changed very much, so it doesn't matter what period you write about.

Q *Your books are full of respect for that human quality of endurance you referred to; but I can't see that there would be as much opportunity for children or young people to demonstrate such a quality here in California as there was perhaps when you were young, when the State was still opening up.*

A That's part of it. There are things like the SLA (Symbionese Liberation Army), but all they want to do is shoot off their guns. Like these kids who held up a bank for a million dollars just to prove they could get it. There's a need. They had nothing to do. They didn't have a job and they didn't have transportation. You can't walk in California, so it's bad if you don't have transportation. But there are things to do. Not necessarily here, but

if they went to Africa they could do a lot. There are millions of kids starving over there. There are challenges all over the world, but nobody's bothered to point them out to the young. Their horizons are so narrow that they don't know anybody ever existed. They don't know that Caesar existed, or Alexander the Great, or Einstein, or anybody else. They're alone. They haven't got transportation. Maybe their old man's out of a job. They've gone hungry a couple of times, and they're all mixed up. There's this Hearst girl backing the SLA. It's so stupid, even the liberals are antagonized.

Q *Even so, she'll probably go down as a folk-hero among some people.*

A Oh sure, particularly if they don't analyze the escapade. For instance, that four million dollars' worth of food. It's just people cramming their stomachs for a couple of meals; instead they could have set up a center where really poor people could benefit—people who are poor materially and mentally and physically. A center like that, if properly funded, might have taken care of 500 people a day with a modest meal for a long time. Instead of this they bought a lot of groceries and threw them around. They were only interested in making a display and showing their guns. I've written against the gun. *The Island Of The Blue Dolphins* was a direct protest against the gun, and the killing of animals and the killing of people.

Q *That's another book that has an Indian girl as its heroine. Why is it that you write so sympathetically about the Indians?*

A I think it is accidental, in the sense that I've lived in a country of Indians. The story of an Indian girl who lives eighteen years on an island alone is a dramatic idea, so I used it as a vehicle for what I wanted to say. If she had been a girl from Iowa or the Mayflower I still would have done it, because of the situation. The same with the Navajo girl in *Sing Down The Moon*, a ready-made situation about a people who were persecuted, uprooted and driven from their homes. Again, *The Black Pearl* is based on a legend current down there below San Diego. Steinbeck also used it. Our stories are quite alike up to the time when the pearl is sold: then they diverge. I think of all this as just an accident, that I was born out here. If I'd been born in the Middle West and stayed in the Middle West, I would come into contact with different legends, probably about early French voyages and so forth. In *Child of Fire* it's a young Spaniard. They are people I've grown up with, people I do know. I have Indian friends, just as I have Spanish and Mexican friends. There's quite a difference between the Spanish and the Mexi-

cans, who are really Indians, or who have Indian blood in them. There are also a lot of different tribes in Mexico. For instance I lived a summer in Patzcuaro, where the Tarascan Indians live, about 9,000 feet above the sea. They were never conquered by any Indian tribe, not even by the Aztecs. They lived in a beautiful little city called Zinzunzan, "the place of the hummingbirds." Then Guzman, a Spaniard looking for gold, came with his five men. He talked with the King, and told him "We come for gold." The King had never seen gold. Instead he gave Guzman beautiful garments made of hummingbird feathers which he promptly threw away. Guzman was sure the King was lying, so he tied him to the tail of a horse, dragged him round the square and threw him on a bonfire. Immediately all the Tarascans, who had never been conquered before, disappeared into the high mountains, and they're still there today. That's a long story. But there was a girl in Patzcuaro, one of eleven Tarascan children, and we took her on as our cook. I modeled my Indian girl on her. This illustrates the mechanism. If I had been in the Middle West it would have been somebody else.

Q *Your books are all told in the first person, through the eyes of the protagonist. Is that because many of them are based on stories you've heard word of mouth?*

A I think it's the easiest way to write, though some of my adult books have been written in the third person. Though I don't think you'd find any evidence of it in my present writing, I have been influenced by Conrad. I was a great admirer of his for many years. What he did was more complex than I am able to handle. Sometimes he would have three narrators—the author, Marlow and Lord Jim, for example—each telling different parts of the same story as they saw it. I think writing in the first person is easier because you don't have to work so hard for suspension of disbelief. When you read that "I did it" there's a tendency to believe what you're being told. You get an almost automatic identification which I think is so important in a story. In *Child of Fire* I have a device which goes back to the Marlow situation in Conrad. I use a parole officer, in charge of fifty children, who tells the story of one particular boy. It has drawbacks of course, because you can only report what you have seen. I have a situation in which the boy leaves San Diego and goes on a tuna clipper to Ecuador, where there's a mutiny and where he's thrown in prison. In the end he escapes and gets back to San Diego. Well, he has to tell this story; there's no other way of getting it. It's not as dramatic as it would have been if the parole officer had gone with him, and so had been able to tell the story himself, like an omnipotent

observer. But that was obviously impossible. So there are penalties.

Q *I understand you are now working on a novel about William Tyndale, the first Englishman to do a creditable version of the Bible. Although this is obviously set in the past, it doesn't seem to have much else to do with your other children's books. Are you doing this as an extension of your own messianic tendencies?*

A I'm terribly interested in his story. He wanted every ploughboy to read the Bible as it came from the original Greek and Hebrew, not as it came from the Vulgate, and not as the priest read it in the pulpit. This is what Tyndale wanted to do, and this is what Tyndale did—and he did it so beautifully that when the King James version came along they used 70 to 75 per cent of Tyndale in it. Today we speak Tyndale. It's extraordinary if you compare the passages he translated from the Greek with the same passages in the Latin. If you are really concerned with something it gets into the fabric of the story and is transmitted to the reader. That was D. H. Lawrence's feeling, and it's certainly one I share. I have only done things that I've been really enthusiastic about, stories that have stirred me. With Tyndale, and with this messianic quirk of mine, I feel that I am performing a mission; it may be a little grandiloquent to call it that, yet that is my feeling. Children speak the language, but they don't know where the hell it came from. They don't know whom to credit for it, and they certainly don't know Tyndale's story, how the man lived in attics and burrows and was pursued by spies all over Germany, Holland and Belgium, attempting to seize him and take him back to England. His Bible was smuggled into England. It had to be, because it was against the law to own it or read it. He very calmly gave up his life for this purpose. He was a hero. Today children don't feel there are important things to do. They take it out on sports—the football players and the baseball players are heroes, so that at any given time we've got 5,000 heroes. But this is a very empty thing; it's heroism delegated. Nobody enjoys sports more than I do, but I don't enjoy them for that reason. I don't think they should be used as a substitute for the meaningful things in life that never occur to children brought up by fathers who are crazy about sports in houses where there aren't any books. And our divorce statistics and our crime statistics are frightening. In this county alone, San Diego, there are 23,000 parolees. In other words, sometime this afternoon you have been in contact with two or three parolees in this area. You can't miss them. And what do you do with them? I'm on a board of directors for one of these crash programs. We run a tranquillity

house where we have twenty or so very young girls and boys who have drug problems. They live in this house and police themselves under certain restrictions and rules. What we're trying to do is put them back in the mainstream. We've been most successful when they've gotten jobs or something to do, and don't have to sit round the house all day, which is lethal.

Q *But one can see why they get like that in an overdeveloped urban society.*

A Young people are terribly restricted on the basis of what we consider important. The country is poisoned by money, so that anybody who doesn't get rich and make a lot of it is considered a failure. There's none of the old idea, still around in some places of the world, that you do your work because you enjoy doing it. Well, the unions have taken over now. If you're a checker at a Safeway store, you get five dollars ninety-five cents an hour, and benefits, so you don't have to worry about a lot of things, the quality of your work for one thing. It's very easy of course to sit here having something quite different to do and talk in general terms. I think it's partly the way schools are run today. Think of the past, when children weren't children but a real part of the family. If the father was a stonemason then the son was a stonemason; and if the mother worked at a loom making tapestries, then the daughter learned to make tapestries. The family was monolithic, as the Tarascans are in Mexico today. The family was very strong, and the children learned trades and were proud of them. By the age of ten or so they were adults. I think children should be given adult responsibilities as soon as possible. Of course, child labor has been abused, as it was in the Industrial Revolution. What we're doing though is extending childhood to infinity, protecting our children from what, for Christ's sake? They're much smarter than we are, much smarter than their parents, certainly in worldly ways. We need to change the fabric of the family so there are books in the home and mothers and fathers reading to their children, instead of this generation gap, children wanting to get out of the house as fast as they can because of restrictions. How this is to be done I don't know. It probably isn't possible. There's some element that is missing. In the Orient the father is honored, and the grandfather and the grandmother are honored. There is honor. But here in America, when you get to be over forty you might as well be dead.

Q *In The King's Fifth it certainly suprised me that a boy of fifteen was entrusted with the post of cartographer on a large exploring vessel.*

A It's an example of what I'm talking about. For instance, our captains and your captains who sailed to the Far East usually retired at the age of thirty.

Q *There is real evidence that a skill like that could be acquired by the time you were fifteen in the Spanish Empire?*

A They learned these skills when they were very young. Coronado was *only* twenty-nine when he led his great expedition. In this story I've just published, *Child of Fire*, the boy was inspired by Coronado. But are there any Coronados around today! There aren't, but there are still things to do. We shouldn't try to make adults out of children too quickly; but we can still give them a sense of responsibility. We can give girls the knowledge that marriage won't solve all their problems, either when they're at junior high, or preferably before. They must realize that, though it's a wonderful idea, there will be more problems, more responsibilities after than before they're married. They have to learn that in marriage you're in trouble if you expect to find in your mate all the men in the world or all the women in the world. I don't think children are prepared for marriage at all. I think the statistics prove it, particularly here in America. California is the worst of all—something like one divorce in every two and one-half marriages. But if you tried to teach sex in the schools, the parents wouldn't stand for it. So the kids educate themselves, without good examples or good sexual relationships. They just bat their heads around until hopefully they find something workable. I'm all for divorce as an escape from horrors, but I still think it's a frightening indication.

Q *Have you had any children yourself?*

A No. My wife (we're both previously divorced) has two children—a girl who's twenty-four and married twice, and a boy still at school.

Q *One can see how this society is bad for marriage. But on the other hand one might say that marriage is bad for this society. To you, obviously, marriage is important.*

A I think it's terribly important. It's an anchor. I don't think you can have much without it, except chaos. There are so many things involved. Children first of all. You can say that children would be better off herded, as Shaw suggested, and taken away from their parents. It's an interesting theory, but it doesn't work. The human psyche is a very fragile thing. Children demand, must have, love. Most children don't have it, and that's one

of our troubles. Children need to feel they have a place, that they're not some object, and that they have a designated and honorable role in a family where everybody contributes. American children don't contribute. They do what they want to do, or what they can get away with. And that's what they're brought up to do. It's difficult to argue with them, so parents don't argue with them. They are afraid to attack the problem because if they talk too much then the children will leave the house. The family is certainly fragmented. I would like to have it all go back to the farm, where children grew up knowing how to use a hoe and milk a cow. To live out in the country and raise a lot of the things that you use—that to me is the ideal life. It may be impossible, but it's still ideal. The last thing that ninety-nine out of a hundred people want to do is get up at four in the morning and milk a cow. But it's a wonderful life because once again the family can become monolithic, one depending upon the other. In the past there have been disadvantages to this—little schooling and a lot of isolation. But now with television it's quite different. This is what I'd like to see. How you get it in an overpopulated industrial society I don't know. Anyway people don't want it. They want what they've got now—a lot of sports and TV.

Q *You're obviously a man of faith. Perhaps the most powerful moment in all your books occurs at the end of *The Black Pearl*, when despite the fact that the pearl has wrought such misfortune to the community, the boy still takes it back to the church where it is enshrined. Where did that come from?*

A I think it's just a logical working out of the plot. At present *The Black Pearl* is being made into a motion picture. I've read the script not that I have any say in it. What the producer does is to have the boy sell the pearl and buy food and clothing for the town. It's the SLA idea again.

Q *And exactly what you avoided.*

A Yes. I said to him, Well, it's dramatic, but I don't like it because, and I'm not a Catholic, you're criticizing the Catholic Church. In essence this pearl could buy twenty or twenty-five thousand dollars' worth of groceries, but in my version the pearl exists and everybody can come and look at it and feel that it belongs to them. That's the theory in the Catholic Church, that the Cathedral and the Virgin are yours. I've seen Indians who have come hundreds of miles to Mexico City to see the Guadalupe Virgin. These Indians come with a vision of the Virgin in their eyes and nothing else. They'd walk over you and never notice.

Adoration, excitement! So the way I closed *The Black Pearl* seemed the logical way.

Q *How much research goes into your books?*

A Certainly a lot for *The King's Fifth*. That was an overly ambitious book when I first started it. All the cities were allegorical cities. I woke up one morning and found that I was competing with Dante. So I quit that and started over.

Q *Are your books intended as a way through the barriers between children and their parents, the problem we have discussed?*

A Yes—I think the written word is one of the few great resources we have. I don't think our television, with its violence and overdisplay of firearms and bosoms and everything, is helpful at all. I have a dedication to the idea of trying to reach this young group that hasn't been abandoned yet, to reach them with a few simple comments about life. I get a lot of letters from children, particularly on *Island of the Blue Dolphins*. They like the idea of fighting for survival; they are challenged by it and they would like to try it themselves.

Q *Do you have any opinions about the commune movement which has been going on for ten years or so now? It seems a variation on the idea of the return to the farm and a closer family existence.*

A In the beginning I was critical about it because I didn't understand what they were trying to do. Then it became associated with marijuana, which, incidentally, I don't think is as bad as cigarettes. It has been degraded by the word "hippy" and by long hair. People don't realize of course that for thousands of years young men wore their hair long. What disappoints me about this youth revolution though, is that very little has come out of it artistically. The best is from the Beatles—they've made a contribution. But in poetry and prose and art there has been very little. They attend Woodstock by the thousands, but that's not productive. The same group with the same excitement 500 years ago would have built cathedrals beautiful to look at.

Q *Perhaps it's a lack of independence among the gatherers at Woodstock that you find hard to take?*

A I do think independence is a very important thing if you can combine it with the family. My father was an autocrat who couldn't care less about his children. I never had a good relationship with him, so I can't speak too much from experience about the family. But I still think we should try to restore it.

Q *Would that help to solve the other problems in America—the racial problem, for instance?*

A It would help. I don't think you can solve the Black problem by any one approach. It's a tremendous task and all acts of good will help.

Q *Do you still have stories you want to write?*

A I have a lot more—three or four at the moment. But it's difficult to get to them because when I quit smoking four years ago I found that I could no longer write at the typewriter. Now I write with a pen. It takes longer to get myself together, using a pen, and I work more slowly.

California, 1974

Among the many books Scott O'Dell has written are: Island of the Blue Dolphins (1960, Newberry Award Winner); The King's Fifth (1966, a Newberry Honor Book); The Black Pearl (1967, also a Newberry Honor Book); The Dark Cane (1968); Journey to Jericho (1969); Sing Down the Moon (1970); The Treasure of Top-el-Bampo (1972) and The Cruise of the Arctic Star (1973).